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Travel Radio Australia and I've caught up with Matthew Thompson who is the General Manager of Public Safety in Queensland for the Surf Life Saving Queensland organisation and Matthew, great to have you on the program. Yeah, great to be here, thanks for having me. Now Matthew, Surf Life Saving in Australia and especially in Queensland because we have a massive massive influx of visitors every year, two million people come here from interstate and there are specific challenges for safety and can you tell us a bit of advice for those people coming into the state about how they can keep themselves safe in the water and on our beaches? Yeah sure, look obviously people love to come to Queensland, we've got wonderful beaches, wonderful coastline and certainly it's a great place to enjoy your time in the state but obviously you know all great things can have their risks and have hazards that present and so when visitors do come to the state we're obviously very keen for them to go down to patrolled locations where our wonderful lifeguards and lifesavers are, you'll see the red and yellow flags that are on the posts marking a safer place to swim and we of course encourage you to swim between the flags if you're choosing to recreate.

They're there for advice as well so if you're a little bit unsure and you just want to get a gauge on what conditions are doing, we appreciate that everybody's got a wide range of experience to swimming not just in the ocean so being as prepared as you can be and talking to our friendly people on the beach is what we advise. Now we're here at the Disaster and Emergency Management Conference on the Gold Coast and I've been speaking to quite a few of the exhibitors here and the use of AI drone technology is really getting great and a new interface with these people with Surf Lifesaving Queensland and it's really making a big difference. Yeah look it absolutely is, we're very proud to be expanding our coastal safety network day in and day out and we're embracing technology as a part of keeping people safe so giving our people the tools and the intelligence to be aware of what risks and hazards are presenting on the beach and in the water and I guess proactively as we can removing people from those dangers before things become an issue so the drones for example are a great opportunity for us to get a bird's eye view on things, gives us great perspective to see what's out there and look at schools of fish whether it be marine creatures moving through the water and make decisions about how best to manage that in that supervised environment where we're located.

Yeah and we used to have the old-fashioned aircraft and helicopters running around at huge expense trying to spot sharks and a lot of that can be taken care of now with drones and AI. Yeah yeah absolutely it can, they're relatively inexpensive to run and get up in the air and have piloted. I suppose there'll never be a full replacement for our lifesavers whether it be on the beach or in the helicopters, we're still proudly running two helicopters on the Sunshine Coast and the Gold Coast but obviously we can use them more effectively and having things like drones, coastal cameras as well as giving our people more technology to use and getting out there and checking on things will allow us to use those more expensive resources in a more effective way.

Now you're very high up in surf lifesaving and how did you get into this role? I suppose you went from the nippers and went all the way through I suppose. Yeah look my lifesaving journey started relatively late in life, I didn't start until later in my my teens when I finished school and I was looking for something to do and my mate said why don't you come down to the local surf lifesaving club and check it all out and the next thing you know I was a lifesaver and I was rowing surf boats through all sorts of oceans but I was very lucky early on to get an opportunity to go and work for the organisation. That was about 15 years ago now and since then I've worked through the public service through a number of emergency services.

About 12 months ago I got an opportunity to come back to where it all started and say it's real to be back in Surf Lifesaving Queensland. Oh yeah and I mean it's not just of course the Gold Coast and the Sunshine Coast, it's right up the coast we've got so many beautiful areas here in Queensland that people can visit and be safe on the beach. Yeah absolutely we've got 58 surf clubs from the Tweed River in the south all the way up to Port Douglas in the north, wonderful spots of coastline through central and northern Queensland and in fact our North Queensland is a well and truly in season at the moment from Mission Beach all the way up to Port Douglas.

They are very busy looking after people because it's outside of marine stinger season of course which runs from November to May and the important thing is always swim between those flags and sometimes I see people just jumping in the water and especially outside the flags and it's just not on and especially don't swim at night because some people get tempted to do that in their holidays. Yeah absolutely if you're not at a supervised location we can't always help and if we can't see you we can't save you so I certainly encourage you to get to a patrolled location if you're heading down to the coast. Thanks and how can people find out more about Surf Lifesaving Queensland and Australia Online Matt? Yeah so if you want to know more about Surf Lifesaving Queensland go to lifesaving.com.au if you're looking for beach safety information we've also got beachsafe.org.au where you can learn all about the safe things to do when you're at the beach.

Above all else means swimming between the red and yellow flags. Thanks Matt for being part of the program. Thanks so much for having me.